HCP905 - corrected German Pigpen report

Review1 by Claude Opus5.5 returned REVISE. All four findings are addressed and root-checked. The reviewer permits closure after these corrections without another round; no new ACCEPT verdict is claimed.

Round-1 corrections checked by root: 346 active geometric glyphs under the unchanged transferred key, plus one canceled geometric field whose underlying letter is not asserted. The existing independent review is REVISE; this revision does not create a new acceptance, marker, PDF or register claim.

Source and scope

The card is `cpc_1899-12-21_DE_Bonn_DE_Berlin_mariechen-03`, dated 21 December 1899 in the portal metadata, addressed to **Fräulein Marie Kühnast, Berlin S 59, Kottbuser Damm 72**. The picture has a red devil and the printed caption **Der hol' die Ansichtskarten!** The address side contains ordinary cursive, postal marks, and a faint pencil mark; no encrypted passage was identified there. Both original images have been inspected and remain unchanged.

Root read General, Description, Attachments in the rendered portal on 2026-10-28: **Not solved**, tagged Pigpen, with no individual transcription or solution attached. Root also inspected all 158 visible AI-register contributions and found no HCP 905 entry. These are bounded checks, not a worldwide novelty claim. See `SOURCES.md` and `source/metadata.md`. The linked generic collection paper is preserved at `../hcp-1081/source/schrodel-2021.pdf`; root checked its illustrated addendum and did not supply a matching individual plaintext or key.

No attached transcription was available. `work/transcript.json` is a **manual shape transcription**, with every position indexed and approximately located in original-image coordinates. It is not OCR.

Method and key

The omitted-J German Pigpen convention was deliberately transferred from the already read related cards **HCP 995 and HCP 1016**. This is a disclosed key transfer, not an independent rediscovery of that key and not use of a supplied HCP 905 plaintext. The opening immediately gave `IA VERD ... NICHT EINMAL DIR KANN ICH'S MEHR RECHT MACHEN`. The remaining rows were then transcribed and audited against that same key. No per-word remapping was introduced.

The shape names describe the strokes drawn: SE=┘, S=⊔, SW=└, E=⊐, O=□, W=⊏, NE=┐, N=⊓, NW=┌. A period after a shape name means an **interior dot**.

Shape	SE	S	SW	E	O	W	NE	N	NW
Plain	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I/J
Dotted, attested	K	L	M	N	O	P	-	R	S

The dotted NE cell is not attested on this card and is not needed by the decoder. Additional shapes: upright stroke I = T, check-like V = U, left angle < = V, upward wedge ∧ = W, dotted upward wedge = Z. Two short strokes above the A or U shape yield Ä or Ü. Those marks are diacritics, not extra alphabetic positions. I and J share a cell; the mechanical output uses I throughout. The initial JA, the later JA, and JEDE are editorial I/J readings.

Literal text

Hyphens separate words on the card. = records a double-stroke line continuation. The canceled field is separately marked, and the abbreviated `VERD....` is not completed into an unrecorded word.

```
JA - VERD....! NICHT - EINMAL -
DIR - KANN - ICH'S - MEHR - RECHT -
MACHEN, WIE - DEINE - LETZTE, -
```

```
IM - ÜBRIGEN - JA, - WIE - AUCH - DIE -
ANDERN - ZWEI - KÜNSTLERKARTEN, -
SEHR - HÜBSCHE [CANCELLED] - UND - DAHER - VON -
MIR - MIT - HERZLICHEM - DANK - ENT=
GEGENGEDOMMENE, IN - ETWAS - MERK=
WÜRDIGEM - TONE - ABGEFASSTE -
SONNENKARTE. ICH - BIN - FROH, DASS - ICH -
SIE - SELBST - VOM - POSTBOTEN - ENTGEGEN=
NAHM. - AUHSERDEM - MUHS - ICH - JEDE - VER=
ANTWORTUNG - FÜR - KÜDINGHOVENER - FILIAL=
POSTVERHÄBTNISSE - ABLEHNEN. SCHLUHS - U. - KUHS
```

The 14 row totals are **17, 20, 20, 21, 24, 23, 23, 25, 22, 28, 29, 27, 32, 36**. Together they account for **347 positions: 346 active + one canceled field** (position 114). All active glyphs receive a key assignment.

Editorial reading and translation

The following is a reading aid, with line continuations joined, word separators removed, HS rendered as modern ss/ß in its four recurring contexts, the apparent D-for-N and B-for-L missing-dot errors corrected, and `u.` expanded. These changes are **not** changes to the literal decoding:

Ja, verd....! Nicht einmal dir kann ich's mehr recht machen, wie deine letzte, im Übrigen ja, wie auch die andern zwei Künstlerkarten, sehr hübsche und daher von mir mit herzlichem Dank entgegengenommene, in etwas merkwürdigem Tone abgefasste Sonnenkarte. Ich bin froh, dass ich sie selbst vom Postboten entgegennahm. Außerdem muss ich jede Verantwortung für Küdinghovener Filialpostverhältnisse ablehnen. Schluss und Kuss.

English translation, preserving the unfinished construction of the first sentence rather than supplying a missing German verb:

Yes, damn...! I can no longer even please you, as [with] your latest sunshine postcard-otherwise, like the other two art postcards, very pretty, and therefore received by me with heartfelt thanks, [but] written in a somewhat peculiar tone. I am glad I received it from the postman myself. Furthermore, I must disclaim all responsibility for the branch-post arrangements in Küdinghoven. End, and a kiss.

`VERD....` is an abbreviated exclamation, approximately “damn...”; its full wording is not present. “Sunshine postcard” translates literal SONNENKARTE, without identifying some other lost card. KÜDINGHOVENER is the directly decoded place adjective; geography is supporting context rather than a reason to assign its glyphs. The first sentence is an elliptical comparison/apposition: *wie deine letzte … Sonnenkarte* may presuppose an omitted *z. B.* or comparable connective. This is a linguistic hypothesis, not cipher text. Row 3 ends at `LETZTE, -` and row 4 continues directly with `IM ÜBRIGEN`; no missing cipher line is inferred. The incomplete syntax is retained rather than silently repaired.

Source anomalies and limits

- **Canceled field, position 114, after HÜBSCHE:** a geometric field has been heavily crossed out. Two heavy vertical strokes cancel the field; its top, right and bottom strokes remain visible, of the ⊐/□ family, with no visible interior dot. The left boundary and underlying letter cannot be assigned reliably from this image. `work/canceled.png` shows it. It is not silently deleted from the inventory or guessed as an N.
- **HS is literal in four places:** AUHSERDEM (259-260), MUHS (268-269), SCHLUHS (341-342), KUHS (346-347). Each first glyph is an undotted cap = H; the following is a dotted top-left corner = S. The period-spelling comparison covers six expected ß words: *außerdem, muß, Schluß, Kuß, daß, abgefaßte*. The first four appear as HS and the last two as SS on the card. This supports the editorial interpretation, but does not establish why the writer chose it or justify replacing the literal H with S. DASS and ABGEFASSTE really do have two dotted top-left corners and remain SS.
- **GEGENGEDOMMENE, position 156:** the ⊐ cell is undotted, hence literal D (E in the shape notation). The nearby dotted ⊐ at position 153 is an N control.

work/review1-pos156-D-rawNN.png and review1-pos153-N-rawNN.png retain fresh nearest-neighbor crops from the original. The conventional intended *entgegengenommene* is editorial only. This apparent dropped-dot slip is handled like the B/L case below; no dot is invented.

- **POSTVERHÄBTNISSE, position 321:** the cup is undotted and therefore literally B. The surrounding word supports an intended L in POSTVERHÄLTNISSE, but no missing dot is invented. See work/l14l.png.
- **Dots under the watermark:** ABGEFASSTE positions 192-193 have small dark interior marks. Raw crop work/l9dots.png and the threshold aid preserve both. The apparent extra arm beside the subsequent T is gray watermark, not a W-shaped pen glyph. ETWAS and FILIAL were also audited in small raw crops rather than inferred from grammar. The fourth glyph of FILIAL has a short upper arm and is classified as I, not T.
- **JEDE and VER:** early provisional readings JENE and VOR were withdrawn after checking the raw small crops. The alleged interior dots were gray watermark. The final inventory has undotted D (275) and undotted E (278). See work/jede.png and work/ver.png beside the masks. Thresholds are supporting displays only: they neither recover missing pixels nor replace the original color image.
- The printed caption, ordinary address, postal dates and pencil mark are not cipher letters. The sender's identity and any implied private history are not established by this decoding.

Geographic and postal context

The address clearly gives **Kottbuser Damm 72**. The arrival mark reads **Postamte 59, 22/12.99**; 59 agrees with **Berlin S 59** in the address. The Bonn postmark is visible, but its posting day is not safely legible here. The portal's date 21 December 1899 is consistent with arrival on 22 December; it is not a fresh reading of the obscured Bonn date.

Küdinghoven is in Beuel, on the right-bank side of Bonn: the [official Bonn municipal page](https://www.bonn.de/bonn-erleben/besichtigen-entdecken/beuel.php?loc=de) lists it among Beuel's districts and describes Beuel as rechtsrheinisch. This is geographic support for the decoded place adjective alongside the Bonn postmark, not proof of the 1899 administrative status or branch-office details.

The six ß spellings above are the period linguistic comparison raised in Review 1, not six encoded ß glyphs. Modern editorial spelling changes *muß/Schluß/Kuß/daß/abgefaßte* to *muss/Schluss/Kuss/dass/abgefasste*, while *außerdem* retains ß. [Duden's edition history](https://www.duden.de/ueber_duden/auflagengeschichte) supports the 1901/1902 standardization chronology, but a new entry-by-entry historical dictionary verification was not performed. Context and provenance details are also recorded in work/review1-context.md; no manuscript intention or historical identity is established by these observations.

Reproduction

From repository root:

```
/Users/tomaspavuk/.cache/codex-runtimes/codex-primary-runtime/dependencies/python/bin/python3 -I
  ciphers/hcp-905/work/decode.py
```

This read-only command verifies all three original source files against their three entries in the frozen batch guard, and seven immutable input hashes including the existing DONE1, REVIEWED1 and review. It checks 59 canonical record hashes, IDs 1-347, exact row totals, all 24 used key classes, saved mechanical and diplomatic readings, regenerated-in-memory pixels for all 14 indexed aids and five original nearest-neighbor review crops. It then re-encodes the complete mechanical character stream under the full fixed inverse key, preserving the canceled field as a sentinel; it is not merely a per-glyph reverse lookup. The diplomatic/J-folded text is independently normalized and checked against the mechanical reading, so stale GEGENGENOMMENE text cannot pass.

The command **does not derive the transcription from pixels**. Hashes, crop reproduction, indices and the whole-key inverse audit internal consistency, not the truth of manual shape classifications. The source controls and retained uncertainty remain necessary. `work/record-sha256.json` lists the exact 59 canonical records, including this solution and notes; historical scratch crops outside that list are not current claims.

`work/indexed-01.png` through `work/indexed-14.png` show every position above the original source pixels. Source-coordinate boxes are contextual and approximate, not exact glyph segmentation. `work/make-aids.py` regenerates those aids and the principal ambiguity crops using Pillow. `work/make-transcript.py` documents the manual classification and coordinates; it is not a solver that infers plaintext from an image.

The broad coverage, long coherent German text, direct key transfer, and repeated internal shape controls support the reading. The manuscript's two apparent missing-dot errors, the four HS sequences, the canceled glyph, and the incomplete first-sentence syntax remain explicitly disclosed. A second agent from the same solver team checking selected crops is not independent provider review.

Response to review 1

The existing `review/REVIEW1.md` verdict is **REVISE**. Its files and `REVIEWED1` remain unchanged. This solver correction has passed root source and reproduction checks; it does not invent a new independent acceptance.

1. **Position 156 / literal missing-dot anomaly - fixed from original pixels.** Fresh nearest-neighbor original crops confirm an undotted ⊐ at 156, contrasting with the clear interior dot at 153. The generator, shape inventory and word notation now use E/D, yielding `GEGENGEDOMMENE`. The diplomatic literal, saved literal, mechanical reading and indexed row 8 now agree. A source-anomaly entry explicitly retains the D while the editorial German restores N. Counts and key are unchanged.
2. **Canceled position 114 - description expanded; letter still unassigned.** The original crop shows two heavy vertical cancellation strokes and remaining top/right/bottom field strokes, consistent with the ⊐/□ family. No interior dot is visible. N (*hübschen*) or E may be linguistic possibilities, but neither is assigned, and the left boundary is not safely established. The inventory still contains exactly one canceled field, not an active letter or deletion.
3. **Context - added to this report text for the later root-controlled report stage.** (a) The official municipal page supports the modern right-bank Beuel/Küdinghoven geographic context, consistent with the Bonn postmark; no 1899 administrative conclusion is drawn. (b) The original arrival mark reads Postamte 59 and 22/12.99; 59 matches Berlin S59. (c) The ordinary street number 72 is now quoted and its raw crop saved. (d) The six period ß contexts are listed explicitly, distinguishing the card's four HS from two SS and the modern editorial forms. That last comparison is a linguistic observation from Review1, not newly completed historical lexicography. The Bonn posting day remains unreadable. No PDF is produced in this correction task.
4. **Elliptical first sentence - clarified.** The note now explains that *wie deine letzte … Sonnenkarte* is likely an elliptical comparison/apposition, perhaps with an omitted *z. B.* The possibility is marked as interpretation. Row 3 LETZTE continues directly into row 4 IM ÜBRIGEN; no missing encrypted line or unrecorded German words are supplied. The English bracketed bridges remain editorial.

The final read-only audit passes: **14 rows; 347 positions; 346 active + one canceled; 24/24 key classes used; three original and seven immutable input hashes; 59 record hashes; all indexed/crop pixels; saved literal/mechanical readings; whole-fixed-key inverse**. The existing reviewer’s read-only comparison decoder was also rerun: 347 positions and no notation differences. This is reuse of existing review evidence, not a new review. Root has inspected the source controls and the complete review response before closure. No watcher or reviewer was launched and no source, existing review, marker, PDF, register entry or Git state was changed by this

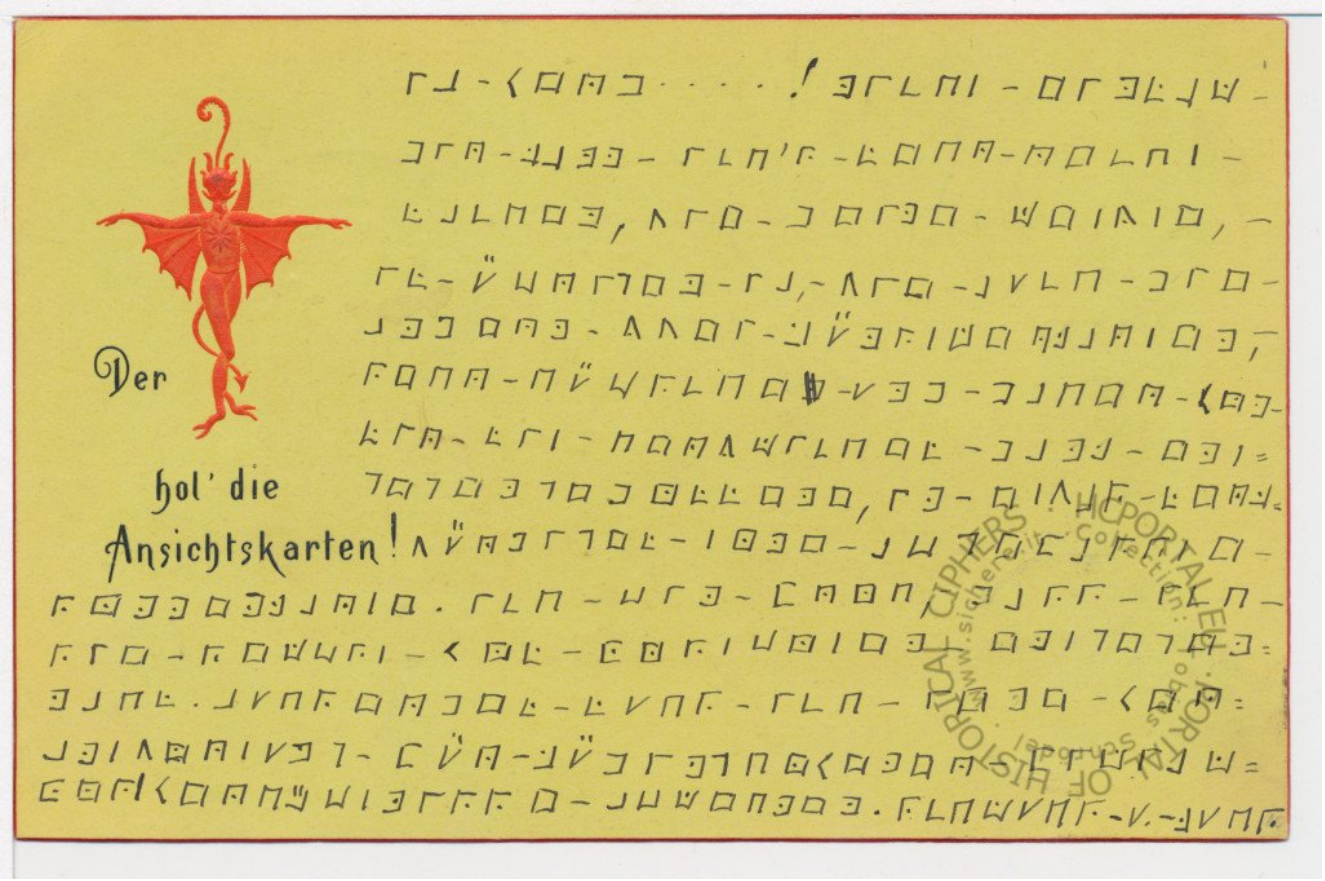
correction.

Root closure checks after review1

Root compared the fresh original-pixel crops with the reviewer evidence. Position156has no interior dot, whereas153has one; literal GEGENGEDOMMENE is retained and the intended N is editorial. The remaining strokes of canceled114are described without assigning an original letter. Address72and arrival Postamt59/22.12.99are visible. The first sentence remains explicitly elliptical, with no invented cipher line or words. All four findings are addressed; the key and meaning are unchanged. The reviewer explicitly permits closure after these local corrections without another review round. Root/helper checking is solver collaboration, separate from the existing Claude Opus5.5 independent review.

The current full337-contribution/303-HC-ID register still omits this target. This bounded check does not prove worldwide novelty. Source/review/old markers remain protected; the59-entry record manifest is intentionally updated only for root-edited SOLUTION and NOTES. The final report and local register entry are prepared before FINAL, with no external submission. Solver name is TODO because no name was supplied for these entries.

Original source photographs



Original picture side, preserved unchanged.



Original address side, preserved unchanged.

Source record and attribution

Portal record: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/905 . All three rendered tabs and both original sides were checked; no individual solution or transcript was attached. Source files are preserved unchanged with hashes in the reproduction record.

- Picture: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/2775/conversions/cpc_1899-12-21_DE_Bonn_DE_Berlin_mariechen-03_pic-large.jpg
- Address: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/2776/conversions/cpc_1899-12-21_DE_Bonn_DE_Berlin_mariechen-03_adr-large.jpg
- Generic collection context only: https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166 . No target plaintext was supplied from that paper.
- Official geographic context: https://www.bonn.de/bonn-erleben/besichtigen-entdecken/beuel.php?loc=de . Modern geography only; the obscured Bonn posting day remains unknown.

Current complete register check:337contributions/303HC IDs, with HCP905absent; recorded in batches/easy-2026-10-28/register-check-pc235-continuation.json. Bounded provenance check, no worldwide novelty claim. Full source history remains in SOURCES.md.